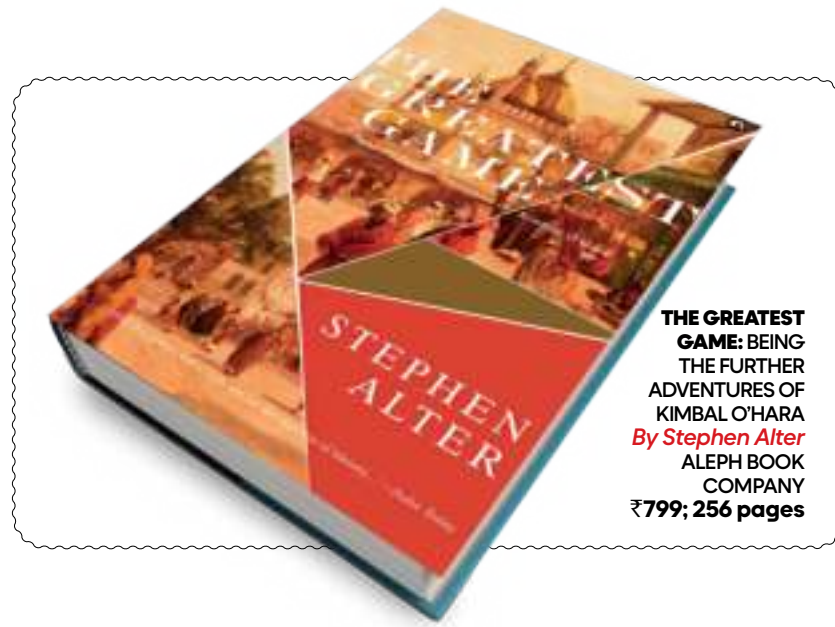
BOOKS ▼

THE GAME IS ON

Stephen Alter spins a splendid tale in his sequel to Rudyard Kipling's *Kim*

The founding idea of Stephen Alter's novel is little short of brilliant. The ageing spy—whether in retirement or on the verge thereof—drawn reluctantly into the strife of the world, is a familiar device in postwar fiction. He has been in the thick of it, seen and seen through it all, and is well-positioned to give one a clear-eyed account of contested histories. John le Carré's *Smiley* is perhaps the best-known, but there are others. Mick Herron's Jackson Lamb in *Slow Horses*—brilliantly rendered by Gary Oldman in the TV series—is a recent example. Alter's ageing spy is none other than Kipling's *Kim*, drawn into the turmoil of India in the moment of the smudgy dawn of Independence—*yeh dagh-dagh ujala*.... The history is nothing if not momentous, and Alter is a skilled writer who has researched his material well—both the fictional world of Kipling's boy-hero, and the fateful and blood-stained midnight hour when India awoke to its "freedom".

The resulting work—*The Greatest Game*—is predictably smooth, propelled by an unflagging narrative zest. This is particularly remarkable because, of course, much of this Partition material is all-too-familiar—the trains full of frightened refugees and worse, plying from Lahore to Amritsar and, be it remembered, *from* Amritsar and Delhi to Lahore. The murderous hordes, the blood and gore, all this is old hat. And the challenge, as ever, is how to make it new, to make it seem worth telling once again.



THE GREATEST GAME: BEING THE FURTHER ADVENTURES OF KIMBAL O'HARA
By Stephen Alter
ALEPH BOOK COMPANY
₹799; 256 pages

Against this backdrop, Alter introduces an assassination plot, targeting Nehru and Gandhi. Brigadier Denys Bromley-Pugh's gang of die-hard colonialists, who are hatching the plot somewhat clumsily, are desperate to stall the Independence that is imminent. They needn't have bothered with the latter target, of course. Indigenous fascists were already at work on that one—and were, in the event, rather more successful. Not least, I suppose, because there wasn't a Kim inventively at work to foil their dastardly designs. So, enjoy.

But it is a pity that someone as gifted as Stephen Alter has deliberately set his bar low: "The novel you hold in your hands makes no pretence of being a scholarly sequel or even a commentary on the Raj. It is simply an effort to spin the yarn a little further...." This is unfortunate. As we know from the writings of le Carré, post-Cold War spy fiction was able to explore the complex realities of the world that had hitherto been represented in the simple binaries of the James Bond universe—good Us, bad Them. Similarly, an ageing Kim, having helped to restore a morally compromised order, was well-positioned to render the colonial deceit and hypocrisy that was soon to be replaced by its post-colonial variant. It is an opportunity that Alter declines. ■

—Alok Rai

AGAINST THE BACKDROP OF PARTITION, ALTER INTRODUCES ***AN ASSASSINATION PLOT—TARGETING NEHRU AND GANDHI***